PSLV and future vehicles owes a lot to this sea lover, which taught us how not to make a rocket.

Space Science & Technology Centre had by now taken shape and, a year after Sarabhai's death in 1971, it was renamed Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre. The centre had several groups working under it: a propellant group headed by Vasant R Gowarikar; a propulsion group with A E Muthunayagam as the head; an aerodynamics group under Y Janardhana Rao; a satellite group under U R Rao; a structures group headed by L Amba Rao; a control, guidance and instrumentation group with S C Gupta at the head; and a systems engineering group under D S Rane. M K Mukherjee headed the materials and quality control group and also general administration. Kalam, heading the SLV-3 project, reported to TERLS director Murthy. Muthunayagam had the additional responsibility of the mechanical engineering group. I reported to him, in the propulsion group.

Relations between various heads were far from cordial; some had a cold war, some others fought openly. Some of the bitter fights were between propulsion group head Muthunayagam, my immediate boss, and propellant group head Gowarikar. Both had ambitions to be the director of VSSC first, and then the ISRO chairman. While Gowarikar became the VSSC director in 1979, neither could reach the top post in ISRO for their own records of partisanship and infighting.

Gowarikar and Muthunayagam never saw eye-to-eye; and this affected me. I can think of no reason for Gowarikar's dislike for me other than that I worked with Muthunayagam, and that my hard work often brought laurels to my boss. Some said Gowarikar was also not amused that I had direct access to the ISRO chairman—something I enjoyed with both Sarabhai and Dhawan. I could not care less, and all I could tell myself was that I had never done anything to appease the bosses and, in fact, my straight forward nature, which irked many others, had endeared me to Sarabhai and Dhawan.

The Gowarikar-Muthunayagam tug-of-war had a history to it. In his experimenting style, Sarabhai had allowed everyone to do anything. While many utilized this freedom with caution and a sense of responsibility, some like Muthunayagam exploited it to fight ego battles. As the propulsion